



156

Cleaning and Lubrication of Bonnet/Hood Catch

Use this advice at your own risk!

Several ARDC and Alfa156.net forum members have reported bonnet catch failures resulting in catastrophic bodywork and glazing damage not to mention a heart stopping panic.

Keen to avoid this, I found the mechanism a little stiff and dirty and applied some spraytack grease, this turned out to be a mistake....



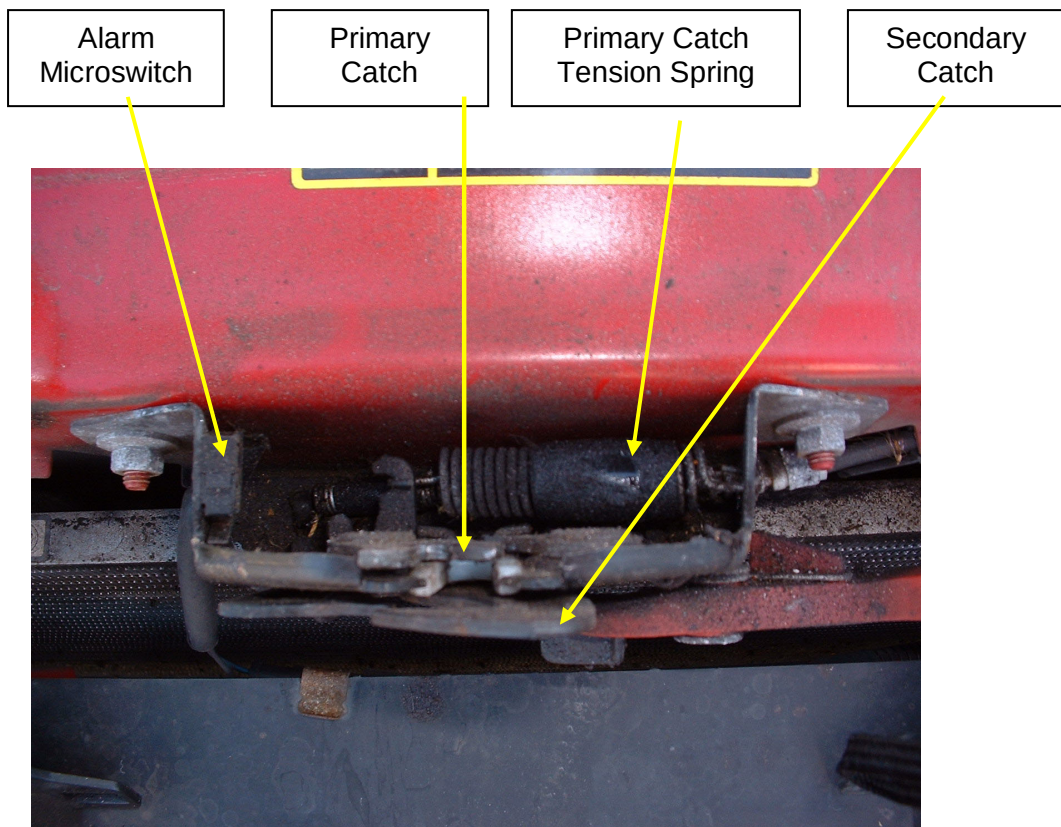
This is the catch as you probably all know, it is encrusted with dirt and grit, which has adhered to the grease. I don't therefore condone adding any more.

The plastic cover is retained by 2 pozidrive screws either side of the catch, one is circled in the photo.



This is what the catch looks like under the cover, even with the plastic cover, you can see that it has accumulated a huge amount of dirt, this car is only a year old. The outer part of the mechanism is the secondary catch and its spring.

The Parts in plan Detail

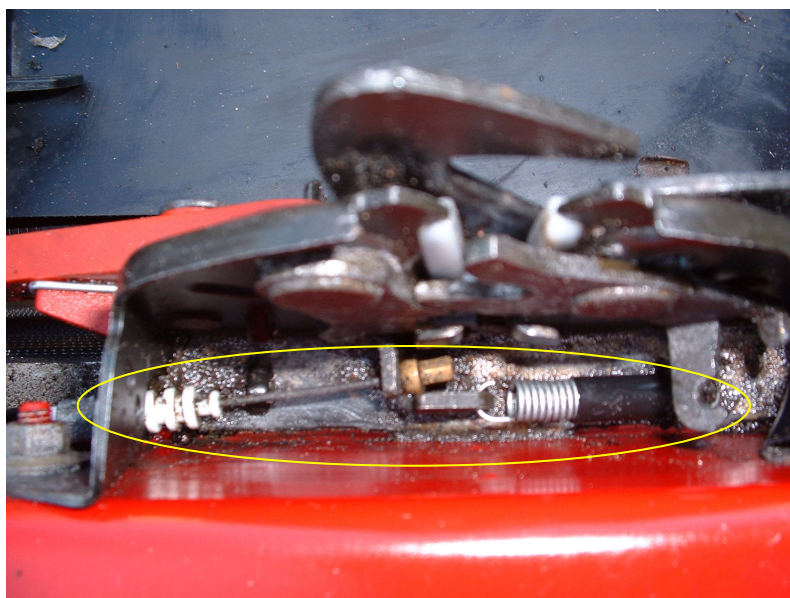


The movement on my catch, although holding the bonnet steadfast, felt gritty in operation and not at all smooth, to begin, I drenched the mechanism in GT20 release and lubrication fluid, although WD 40, Duck Oil or similar products would work just as well, loosening the dirt, flushing it out and leaving lubricant behind, displacing water



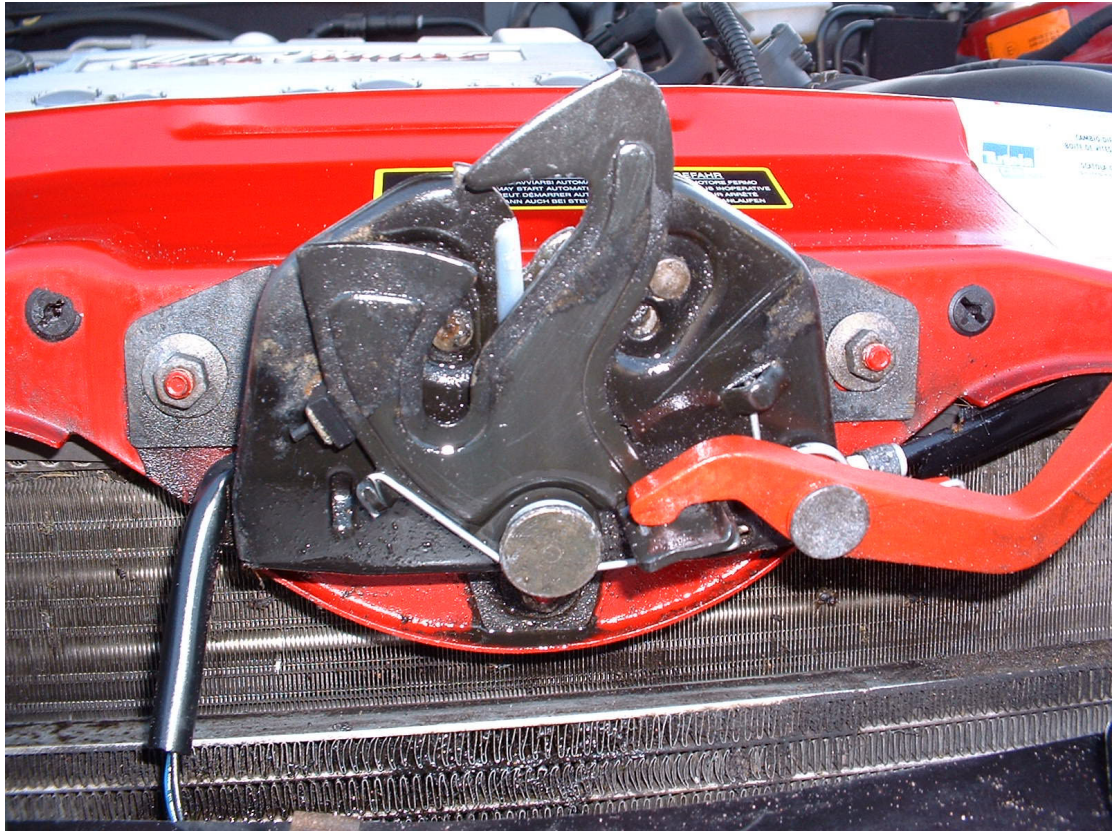
as it does so. As you can see it quickly cleaned up the secondary (outer) catch mechanism, it pays to have some rags below to catch the liquid as it falls. Keep spraying until the mechanism is completely clean, I also used cotton buds to assist in cleaning it right up. Continue this process until the mechanism moves freely and the spring returns the catch sharply to its locked position.

The inner primary catch is a bit harder to clean, though the little lever microswitch for the alarm is easily cleaned with the spray and some cotton buds, the spray will assist in displacing any water that may have found its way inside.

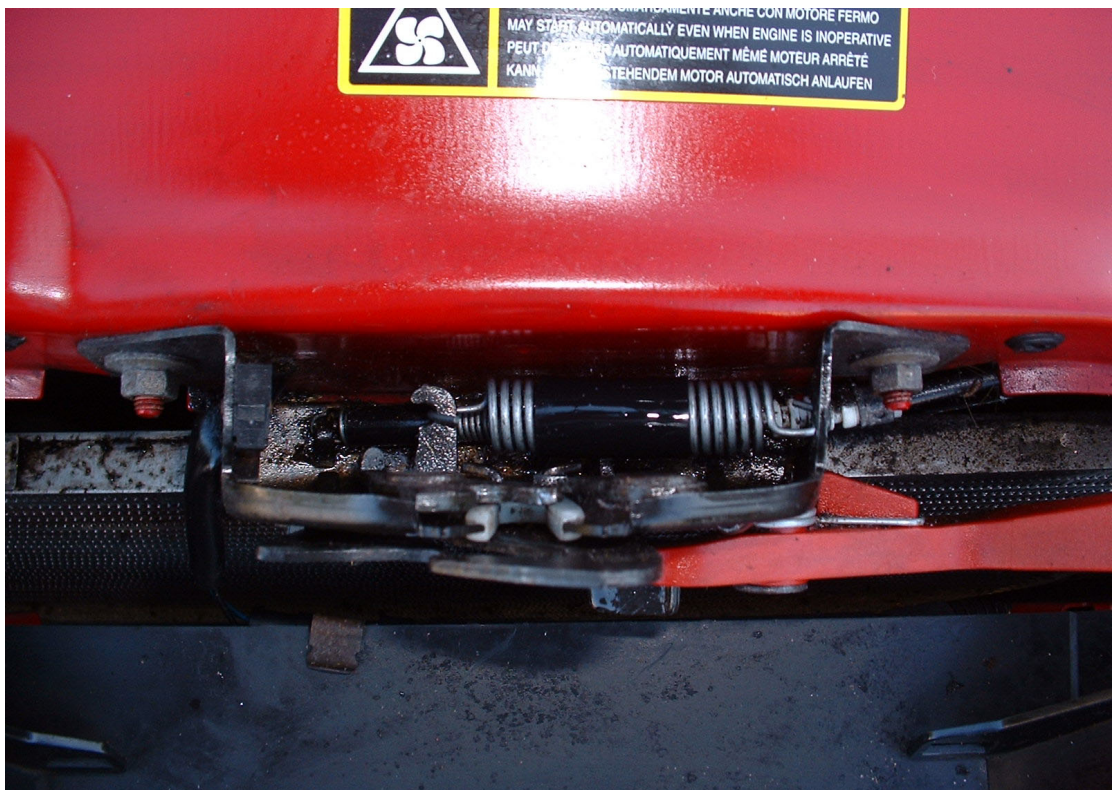


Spraying this from above though was not really satisfactory and the grit could still be felt in the main tension spring, therefore it was removed from the circled area with long nosed pliers and cleaned up off the car before replacing it carefully. Make a note of how it was attached before you remove it to ensure it goes back in the right way round as it is

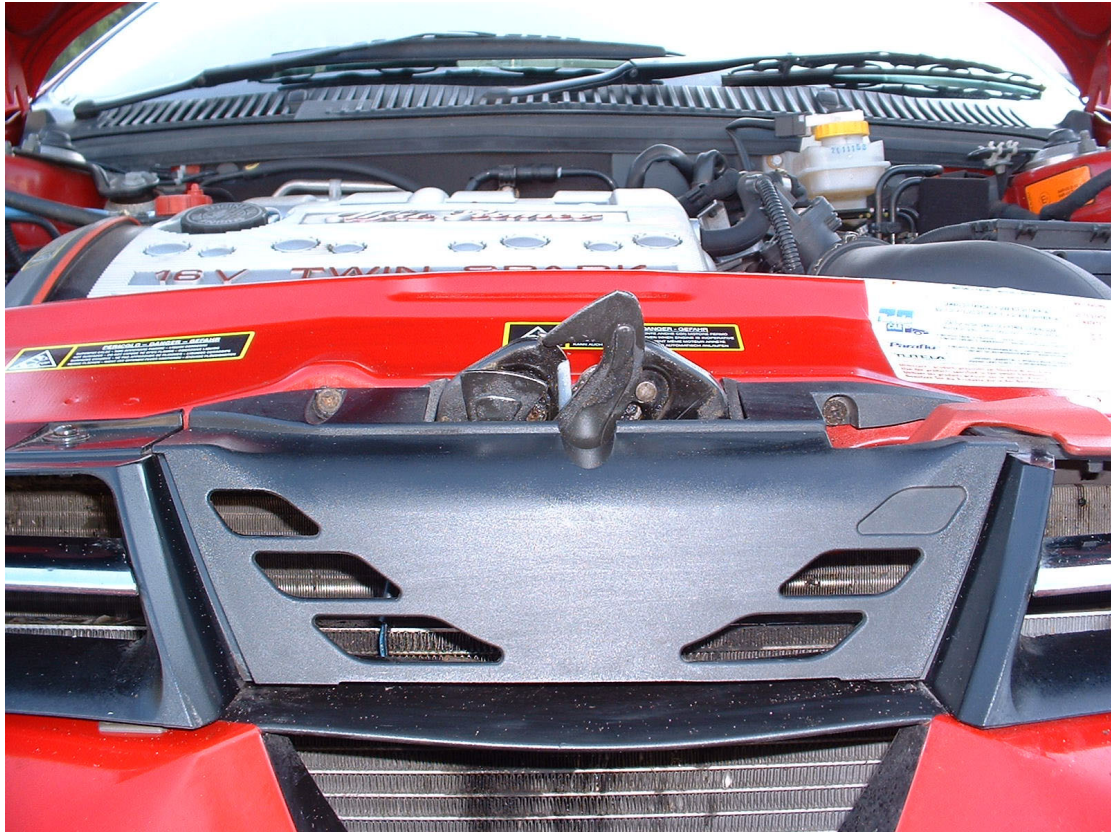
asymmetrical. The smaller spring you see in the picture above tensions the release cable..



These pictures show the mechanisms fully cleaned and lubricated, the catches should move smoothly under pressure and return strongly to their latch positions. Quite an improvement on the earlier images, the dirt on the radiator and condenser are due to me not protecting them during this process – be warned!



At this stage, replace the plastic cover.



Now – IMPORTANTLY close the bonnet and pull on it as hard as you can, it should stay steadfastly closed. NOW pull the bonnet catch and try and pull the bonnet past its second latch without operating the under bonnet lever, again, this should hold fast, then ensure the second catch opens, then drop it back onto the secondary latch and pull it again.

Repeat this 3 or 4 times to ensure complete security, if it slips, there is likely to be a problem with the springs, or the alignment of the mechanism or hook on the bonnet itself – GET HELP.

I recommend removing the plastic cover and spraying the mechanism every 6 months, repeating this cleaning exercise when necessary.



Remember to close the bonnet when you are finished!

And **CHECK CHECK CHECK** everytime you close it.

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